

# Delivering your baby

In the second stage, the finish line is in sight as you actively push your baby out into the world.

As you enter the second stage of labor, you will probably experience an overwhelming desire to bear down. Once your doctor has established that you are fully dilated and are ready to start pushing, you may start to feel more in control of your labor since your pushing helps move your baby farther down into the pelvis.

## The second stage

The second stage of labor starts when your cervix is completely open, at 10 cm, and ends with the birth of your baby. This stage usually lasts for around 45 minutes to two hours for a first labor and from 15–45 minutes in subsequent deliveries. It may last longer if you have an epidural. The second stage is intense and during this time your contractions will become stronger, but may occur less frequently, around every two to five minutes. At this point you may feel a sensation of fullness in your vagina or bowel and have a strong urge to push. Many women find labor pains more bearable in the second stage since they can now actively work with the contractions and push their baby out. Other women find this a particularly hard part of labor because they start to feel exhausted from the effort of prolonged pushing.

## Second stage positions

Although you may be tired and want to lie down, it's recommended that you resist this urge in the second stage. Your partner and nurse can give you plenty of support to help you adopt the most comfortable position.

**Staying upright** Adopting an upright position during the second stage of labor has several advantages. The main one is that you are using gravity to assist your baby's descent, which will also help you bear down and push. Being upright can also improve the alignment of your baby in the birth canal; can increase the efficiency of your contractions; and widens the passageway through the pelvis.

There is also evidence that adopting upright positions in the second stage of labor can reduce the length of time you take to bear down and give birth, and make it less likely that you will have an instrument delivery or [episiotomy](#) (see [Assisted birth](#)).

**Which positions to adopt** Upright positions during the second stage of labor include upright sitting and squatting positions.

If you prefer a sitting position, try to sit in an upright or semi-recumbent position. If you adopt a sitting position on a bed, sitting at a 45-degree angle can help your breathing and reduce the risk of a condition known as aortocaval compression, which can affect how well your blood is circulated around your body and to your baby. This is caused by the weight of your uterus and the baby pressing on major blood vessels (the aorta and vena cava), reducing the amount of oxygen that circulates around your body, which makes you feel light-headed and dizzy. If this happens, you will be advised to lie on your left side to relieve pressure and increase the amount of oxygen that is circulating.

Kneeling or squatting increases the pelvic outlet, so many women will naturally adopt a squatting or all-fours position to give birth since they find that this is the most comfortable and easy position in which to deliver their baby. Upright squatting and kneeling positions help increase your pelvic outlet by around 28 percent compared to when you're in a lying-down position. This means that there is more room for your